Lead Broker Blueprint by Lorenzo Marietti

Module 7 — Starting from Zero

The First 90 Days Playbook

Week-by-week milestones, capital deployment schedules for four starting budgets, decision-tree for continue/pause/pivot at each checkpoint, and the honest framework for when to walk away.

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How to use this playbook

Module 7 explains the four capital scenarios ($1k, $5k, $15k, $50k) and the readiness assessment for entering this business. This playbook tells you what to DO in each of those scenarios across the first 90 days — the most fragile period in any new operation.

Read it before you spend your first dollar. Read it again at the start of each week of the first 13 weeks. The plan is not optional; the discipline of following one is what separates operators who survive from operators who don't.

Three operating principles

1. Survive cash first; growth second.

90% of new lead-broker operations that fail die from cash exhaustion before product-market fit. The plays below preserve cash aggressively in the first 30 days, deploy moderately in days 31-60, and only escalate in days 61-90 if the operating evidence supports it. The most expensive mistake in this business is scaling spend before quality is dialed in.

2. Decisions get measured at checkpoints, not in real time.

Every day will produce numbers that tempt you to react. Don't. Set hard checkpoints at week 4, week 8, week 12. Between checkpoints, follow the plan. At checkpoints, evaluate honestly against pre-set criteria. The discipline of holding to the plan between checkpoints is what makes the checkpoint data meaningful.

3. Your first quarter is information, not income.

Treat the first 90 days as paid market research. You're buying real information about your chosen vertical, your buyer relationships, your channel mix, and your own capacity to operate. If you make money in the first 90 days — great. If you don't, the question is whether the information you bought was worth the cash you spent. Both can be true.

The four starting scenarios

Module 7's core framework defines four realistic starting budgets. Each scenario produces a meaningfully different 90-day plan. Find yours below.

Scenario A — Bootstrap (~$1,000 starting capital)

The hardest scenario. Most operators starting here don't make it through 90 days. Those who do are usually doing this as a side operation alongside another income source.

- Stack: Tier 1 (~$200/mo).
- Ad spend budget: $500-$700 for the entire first 90 days.
- Cash reserve at day 90: ideally $200+ left.
- Strategy: Outreach-heavy, paid-acquisition-minimal. Get one buyer signed via your existing network, deliver 5-10 leads using ad spend, learn what works, save the rest. Pivot to bigger spend in months 4-6 only after the first buyer relationship is proven.
- Realistic 90-day outcome: 1-2 buyer relationships, 10-30 leads delivered, $500-$2,000 in revenue, near-break-even net.

Scenario B — Lean ($5,000 starting capital)

The most common realistic starting position. Enough to test seriously without betting the house.

- Stack: Tier 1 ($200-$400/mo).
- Ad spend budget: $2,500-$3,500 across 90 days.
- Cash reserve at day 90: $500-$1,000 ideally.
- Strategy: Real paid-acquisition test. ~$30-50/day ad spend in your chosen vertical/geo. 2-3 buyer relationships signed. Active focus on the highest-leverage channel for your vertical.
- Realistic 90-day outcome: 2-3 buyer relationships, 50-150 leads delivered, $4,000-$12,000 revenue, modest net profit if quality holds.

Scenario C — Capitalized ($15,000 starting capital)

Enough to run a proper test across multiple channels, hire light help (a VA or a part-time intake agent), and survive a quarter of slower-than-expected ramp.

- Stack: Tier 1 graduating to Tier 2 by day 60.
- Ad spend budget: $8,000-$10,000 across 90 days.
- Cash reserve at day 90: $2,000-$4,000 ideally.
- Strategy: 2-3 channels tested in parallel. 3-5 buyer relationships signed. Part-time outsourced intake agent ($800-$1,500/mo). Begin BI tooling and proper attribution.

- Realistic 90-day outcome: 3-5 buyer relationships, 200-500 leads delivered, $15,000-$45,000 revenue, real operating margin established.

Scenario D — Funded ($50,000 starting capital)

Enough to build the operation properly from day one — Tier 2 stack, dedicated intake team, multi-channel acquisition, real reporting infrastructure.

- Stack: Tier 2 from day one (~$1,500-$3,000/mo).
- Ad spend budget: $25,000-$35,000 across 90 days.
- Cash reserve at day 90: $5,000-$10,000 ideally.
- Strategy: 3-5 channels tested in parallel, 5-10 buyer relationships pursued, dedicated 1-2 person intake team, weekly buyer review meetings.
- Realistic 90-day outcome: 5-10 buyer relationships, 500-1,500 leads delivered, $40,000-$120,000 revenue, structural operating margin.

The week-by-week plan

Below is the operating cadence for Scenario B (Lean, $5k). Adapt to your scenario by multiplying or dividing spend and team-size assumptions. The structure of the weeks is the same regardless of scenario.

Week 1 — Foundation

- Day 1-2: Read Module 1, Module 2 (with the Niche Evaluation Worksheet). Pick your vertical.
- Day 3-4: Read Module 3 (Regulatory Landscape). Set up business entity, compliance posture, privacy policy.
- Day 5-6: Read Module 4 + the Landing Your First Buyer Relationships playbook. Build your initial target list of 40-60 prospective buyers.
- Day 7: Send your first 10 buyer-outreach emails. LinkedIn-connect to all 10.

Week 2 — Stack and supply

- Day 8-9: Sign up for Tier 1 stack (Unbounce, TrustedForm, DNC.com, Ringba/CallRail, HubSpot). Build first landing page.
- Day 10-12: Read Module 5 + the Cold-to-Warm Playbook + Modern Channels deliverable. Pick your initial 2 acquisition channels (typically Google Ads + NextDoor for service businesses; Google Ads + niche newsletter for finance verticals).
- Day 13-14: Send second round of outreach to remaining 20-30 prospects in your target list. Continue daily outreach cadence.

Week 3 — Launch acquisition

- Day 15-17: Launch Google Ads campaign at $20-40/day. Conservative bidding. Single landing page per ad group.
- Day 18-19: First leads start arriving. Run intake within 5 minutes of submission. Document everything.
- Day 20-21: First buyer discovery calls (the outreach from week 1-2 should be producing 2-5 calls by now). Use the discovery call playbook (Module 4 deliverable Part 4).

Week 4 — First checkpoint

Stop. Evaluate. The Week 4 checkpoint determines the next 60 days. Three numbers to assess honestly:

- Leads generated to date: target ≥ 20.
- Buyer discovery calls held: target ≥ 3.

- Cash burn vs plan: should be ≤ 40% of total 90-day budget.

Decision tree:

1. All three on target → continue per plan.
2. Lead volume light but buyer interest strong → re-allocate ad spend more aggressively to working channel; accept slower ramp on channels not working.
3. Buyer interest light but lead volume strong → re-prioritize buyer outreach. Possibly broaden vertical or geography.
4. Cash burn high and traction light → cut paid spend immediately. Continue outreach. Re-assess at week 6 not week 8.

Week 5-6 — First pilot

- Sign the first pilot agreement (use the structure in Module 4 playbook Part 5). 5-10 leads over 30 days.
- Deliver pilot leads against the agreed qualification spec. Daily summary to the buyer.
- Continue outreach: 5-10 new prospects per week. Refresh weekly.
- Continue acquisition at established daily budget. Don't scale up during the pilot — focus 100% on quality.

Week 7-8 — Second checkpoint

Decision tree at Week 8:

5. First pilot succeeded, second pilot in motion → continue, begin scaling ad spend modestly (~25%).
6. First pilot is borderline → extend pilot another 30 days at same volume; do NOT scale acquisition.
7. First pilot failed → diagnose honestly (was it qualification spec? quality drift? buyer-side intake issue?). Decide whether to fix and try again, or pivot vertical entirely.
8. No pilot signed at week 8 → STOP acquisition. The funnel is broken upstream of you. Either the offer isn't compelling enough or the targeting is wrong. Diagnose before continuing.

Week 9-10 — Convert pilots to LPAs

- Negotiate and sign the full LPA with successful pilot buyer(s). Use Module 4 negotiation playbook Part 6.
- Onboard buyer #2 pilot if not already underway.
- Begin the Tier 2 stack upgrade if scenario budget permits.
- Document operating SOPs as they stabilize — intake script, dispute response, return handling.

Week 11-12 — Operational rhythm

- Daily morning operational review: yesterday's volume, quality flags, buyer status.
- Weekly buyer-relationship review: communicate proactively on volume, quality trends, payment status.
- Continue outreach for buyers 3-5. Maintain cadence.
- Begin scoping which Tier 2 tooling adds you'll graduate to in days 91-120.

Week 13 — Third checkpoint and quarterly review

End of first 90 days. Pull the full numbers.

- Total revenue.
- Total cost (ad spend + stack + labor).
- Net contribution.
- Active buyer relationships.
- Cash on hand vs. starting capital.
- Hourly time investment.
- Honest self-assessment: do you want to keep doing this?

Decision tree:

9. Profitable + want to continue → scale up. Move to Tier 2 stack, hire help, formalize processes. Begin planning year 2.
10. Break-even + want to continue → continue at current cadence. The next 90 days will show whether you're trending toward profit. Most operators hit real profitability between months 4-9.
11. Losing money + still want to continue → diagnose specifically. Is it CAC, qualification rate, buyer accept rate, payment delays? Pick ONE thing to fix in the next 30 days and re-evaluate.
12. Losing money + don't want to continue → walk away. Recover what you can. The information you bought is real, even if the cash didn't materialize. Many successful operators have one or two failed ventures in their past.

The five most common first-90-day pitfalls

Pitfall 1 — Scaling ad spend before quality is proven

New operators see one $230 commission and immediately 5x their ad spend. The next batch of leads underperforms because the campaign quality wasn't actually stable. Two weeks in, you've burned half your runway. Rule: only scale ad spend after 30+ days of stable qualification rates AND buyer-accept rates.

Pitfall 2 — Ignoring outreach in favor of acquisition

Most new operators are technically inclined and prefer Google Ads to cold emails. They run ads, generate leads, and discover at day 30 that they have no buyers to sell them to. Outreach has to start IN WEEK 1 even if acquisition feels more productive. Lead generation and buyer development happen in parallel, not sequentially.

Pitfall 3 — Vague qualification spec

Vague qualification specs are the #1 cause of pilot failure. "Homeowners with HVAC need" produces 60% qualified, 40% disputes. "Single-family homeowners with system age 8+ years, replacement timeline 0-90 days, not currently engaged with another contractor, in [list of ZIPs]" produces 90% qualified, 5% disputes. Pin down the spec BEFORE the first lead ships.

Pitfall 4 — Confusing busy with productive

New operators work 14-hour days on low-leverage tasks. Re-designing the landing page for the third time. Re-tuning ad copy that's converting fine. Researching tools they don't need yet. Rule: every day, the FIRST 2 hours go to the highest-leverage activity — usually buyer outreach. Everything else fills the remaining time, not the reverse.

Pitfall 5 — Single-buyer dependency

Operators who land their first buyer relax, ramp delivery, and forget to land buyer #2 and #3. Two months later, buyer #1 reduces volume or churns; revenue collapses overnight. Rule: from the day you sign the first pilot, treat "sign buyer #2" as the most important task on your list.

When to walk away — the honest framework

Some people will read every page of this Blueprint, follow the plan exactly, and still not produce a viable business. That's possible. It's not common, but it's possible. The reasons are usually one of a few:

Reason 1 — The vertical isn't viable for your geography or scale

Some sub-verticals are oversaturated in some metros. Some buyers are concentrated regionally and you happen to be outside the geography. If after 12 weeks you can't sign a single pilot, the issue may be that your initial vertical/geo selection was wrong.

Mitigation: try ONE pivot. Switch verticals (using the Niche Evaluation Worksheet again with fresh data) or switch geography. Give the new selection 60 days. If that also fails, the structural fit may genuinely not be there for you in this category.

Reason 2 — Your channel mix is wrong for the vertical

Google Ads + NextDoor works for HVAC. It does not work for Medicare (which is heavily SEO + direct mail + radio). Operators who try to force-fit one channel mix across verticals often discover the channel was the bottleneck, not the operator.

Mitigation: at week 8, evaluate whether you're using the right channels for your vertical (Module 5 + Modern Channels deliverable have the vertical-specific guidance). If the answer is no, pivot the channel mix before pivoting the vertical.

Reason 3 — The operating rhythm doesn't fit your life

Lead brokering at any meaningful scale requires same-day responsiveness, daily attention, and quick problem-solving. Operators with full-time jobs, young children, health issues, or other significant obligations sometimes find the operating rhythm impossible to sustain. That's a valid reason to walk away.

Mitigation: at week 6-8, assess honestly whether you can sustain the daily cadence for another 12+ months. If not, either hire someone to take it over, partner with someone who can, or accept that the business will plateau at a level that fits the time you can give it.

Reason 4 — You don't like the work

Some operators discover by week 6 that they hate doing intake calls, hate negotiating with buyers, hate dealing with disputes. The Blueprint can teach you HOW to do all those things — it can't make you enjoy them. If the work itself is grinding you down, you'll eventually leave; better to leave at 90 days than at 24 months.

Mitigation: hire the parts you hate (intake agents, account managers) and focus your time on the parts you find energizing. Most successful operators at scale aren't doing intake calls themselves — they're managing a team that does. If the management itself is what you hate, this business may not be your business.

The walking-away protocol

If you decide to walk away, do it cleanly:

13. Honor every existing buyer commitment through the agreed lead delivery.
14. Wind down ad spend immediately. Pause campaigns; don't delete (you may come back).
15. Cancel subscriptions you don't need.
16. Preserve compliance documentation for 4+ years (TrustedForm certificates, DNC records, call recordings).
17. Write yourself a memo about what you learned. Six months from now you'll be glad you have it.
18. Request a refund if within the 30-day window. Otherwise keep the Blueprint as reference material — what you learned is still real even if you didn't deploy it.

> *Most people who buy this Blueprint will not build a real business. That's the honest math of any field. The ones who DO build real businesses are the ones who follow the plan, hit the checkpoints honestly, and keep going when the first 90 days produce uncertain results. The work is repeatable. The discipline is what's rare.*
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> *— Lorenzo*
> Lead Broker Blueprint